The SaaS Starting Point

Test First. SaaS Second.

A preparation framework for serious builders.

No hype.

No shortcuts.

No income promises.

This document is not about tools.

It is not about infrastructure.

It is not about code.

This is your preparation phase.

And if you take this phase seriously, everything that comes after becomes calmer, cheaper, and more controlled.

Before You Continue

There is a clear separation:

This document = preparation.

The YouTube channel = execution.

This document helps you:

- Count the cost (time, money, energy)
- Shape a viable idea
- Reduce risk before building
- Think like a tester, not a dreamer

The videos assume you have already done this homework.

In the videos, I will show:

- Infrastructure
- Setup
- Deployment
- Backups
- Vendor decisions
- Real systems, live on screen

But if you skip this preparation, you build on guesswork.

Preparation doesn’t slow you down.

It prevents you from rebuilding.

Who This Is For

This document is written for three types of people.

1. The Complete Beginner

You have no audience.

No clients.

No idea yet.

You just see the opportunity in SaaS and want to start properly.

Your focus: reduce confusion and avoid expensive experiments.

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2. The Solo Builder With an Idea

You have a concept.

Maybe even a rough sketch.

But you are unsure:

- Is it viable?
- Is it realistic?

- Is it worth the time?

Your focus: narrow scope and validate commitment.

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3. The Niche Insider

You already:

- Have clients
- Have an audience
- Work in a specific industry

You want to build software for that group.

Your focus: avoid overbuilding and avoid fragile decisions.

You are not behind.

You are simply at the stage where clarity matters more than speed.

And that’s a good place to be, because this is where you avoid the mistakes most people make.

The Lens: Risk × Impact

For 12 years, my job as a software tester was simple:

Find where systems break.

Understand what makes them stable.

Not in theory.

In real environments.

When evaluating risk, I look at two things:

1. How likely is it?
2. What happens if it does?

That’s how we’ll look at your SaaS idea.

If you skip validation:

- Risk = high
- Impact = months wasted

If you choose expensive infrastructure too early:

- Risk = moderate
- Impact = thousands lost

Preparation reduces impact before it becomes expensive.

What You Actually Need to Start

You do not need:

- Venture capital
- A co-founder
- Advanced engineering skills

You need:

- 5–10 focused hours per week
- €0–€50 during preparation
- Emotional discipline
- Willingness to think clearly

If you cannot commit consistent time, do not start yet.

SaaS rewards consistency more than brilliance.

You don’t win because you’re the smartest person in the room.

You win because you kept going while others jumped to the next idea.

Step 1 — Define a Narrow Outcome

SaaS does not start with an idea.

It starts with an outcome.

Bad:

"AI marketing platform."

Better:

"Generate compliant cold outreach emails for Dutch accountants."

The more specific you are, the less fragile your idea becomes.

Vague ideas collapse under pressure.

Clear outcomes survive.

Action

Write one sentence:

"I help [specific user] achieve [specific result] without [specific friction]."

If it takes more than one sentence, it is not clear enough.

AI Prompt (Use in ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini)

You are a product strategist and risk analyst.

Your job is to evaluate the clarity of a SaaS concept.

I am considering building a SaaS for:

[NICHE OR TARGET USER]

The intended outcome is:

[DESCRIBE YOUR IDEA]

Your task:

1. Rewrite the outcome into a single, narrow, testable sentence.
2. Identify where the scope is vague.
3. Suggest how to reduce the scope by 50%.
4. Highlight potential risks if the scope stays broad.

Do not generate new features.

Focus only on clarity and scope reduction.

Return:

- Revised outcome
- Risk analysis
- Simplified version

Step 2 — Validate With Commitment

Validation is not compliments.

Validation is commitment.

If people say:

“That sounds cool.”

That means nothing.

Commitment looks like:

- Paying
- Pre-ordering
- Signing a written agreement
- Allocating real time

If you don’t validate first, the impact can be severe:

- 3 months of building
- €1,500 in hosting
- Emotional exhaustion

And nothing to show for it.

Action

Deliver the outcome manually first.

Track:

- Repetition
- Friction
- What clients struggle with

Repeated friction is automatable friction.

AI Prompt

You are a validation coach and behavioral analyst.

I want to validate this outcome:

[INSERT YOUR NARROW OUTCOME]

My target user is:

[INSERT NICHE]

Generate:

1. A simple manual validation plan that costs €0.
2. 3 direct questions that test willingness to commit (not opinions).
3. A script to ask for pre-payment or real commitment.
4. A list of red flags that indicate false validation.

Focus on real-world commitment.

Avoid theoretical market research advice.

Step 3 — Define the Minimal Viable Outcome (MVO)

We are not building a “Minimal Viable Product.”

We are defining a Minimal Viable Outcome.

One workflow.

One result.

One job.

Nothing more.

If your first version needs:

- Roles
- Dashboards
- Advanced settings

You are overbuilding.

If you don’t define boundaries now, you’ll pay for that later —

in time, in money, or in frustration.

Action

Write clearly:

Included:

- Automatic generation of property summary PDFs
- Secure upload of listing data
- One export format

Excluded:

- Multi-user roles
- CRM integrations
- Advanced analytics
- White-label features

Payment trigger:

- User submits payment before accessing generation tool

Completion trigger:

- Property summary PDF successfully generated and delivered

If your workflow exceeds 5–7 core steps, reduce it.

When you narrow your outcome, you remove confusion.

Because confusion is what makes projects fragile.

AI Prompt

You are a software scope reduction specialist.

I am building a SaaS for:

[NICHE]

The outcome is:

[OUTCOME]

Here is what I think it includes:

[LIST FEATURES]

Your task:

1. Reduce this to a Minimal Viable Outcome.
2. Remove anything non-essential.
3. Define what must be excluded.
4. Identify the single payment trigger.
5. Identify the single completion trigger.

Focus on simplicity and clarity.

Assume the founder is non-technical and must keep complexity low.

Return a clean MVO summary.

Step 4 — Count the Cost

This is where most founders avoid thinking.

Ask:

- How much time per week?
- How many months until first revenue?
- What is the worst-case financial loss?

If you build for 6 months at €250/month:

€1,500 lost.

Risk × Impact.

Think before you commit.

This is not about fear.

It's about control.

When you see the numbers clearly, the fear reduces.

AI Prompt

You are a risk analyst with experience in SaaS financial planning.

I am considering building:

[DESCRIBE IDEA]

Assume:

• Monthly infrastructure cost: [X]

• Weekly time investment: [X hours]

• Timeline: [X months]

Calculate:

1. Worst-case financial exposure.
2. Worst-case time investment.
3. Emotional risk indicators (burnout, motivation loss).
4. Break-even threshold.

Be conservative.

Highlight where over-optimism is likely.

Step 5 — Preparation Complete

If you have:

- A narrow outcome
- Real commitment
- A defined Minimal Viable Outcome
- A realistic cost calculation

You are ready to build.

Now — and only now — go to the YouTube channel.

There you will find:

- Infrastructure walkthroughs
- Setup tutorials
- Vendor comparisons
- Deployment control
- Backup restoration
- Lean stack decisions

Everything practical.

Everything shown live.

Final Note

This document is not here to impress you.

It's here to protect you.

Because once you see the path clearly, the fear drops.

And once the fear drops, execution becomes possible.

Structure first.

Then SaaS.

You are not late.

You are early enough to do this properly.

Steve